

# THE AI PREMIUM TRAP

*What 1,000 verified micro-SaaS businesses reveal about paying for a label, instead of a ledger.*

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Source: TrustMRR verified-revenue marketplace · 1,000-row dataset · frozen 30 Jul 2026

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# TrustMRR, in three numbers

*Every listing is tied to a connected payment provider — Stripe, RevenueCat, Paddle and others — so the revenue is verified, not self-reported.*

1,000

VERIFIED STARTUPS ANALYZED

\$13.5M

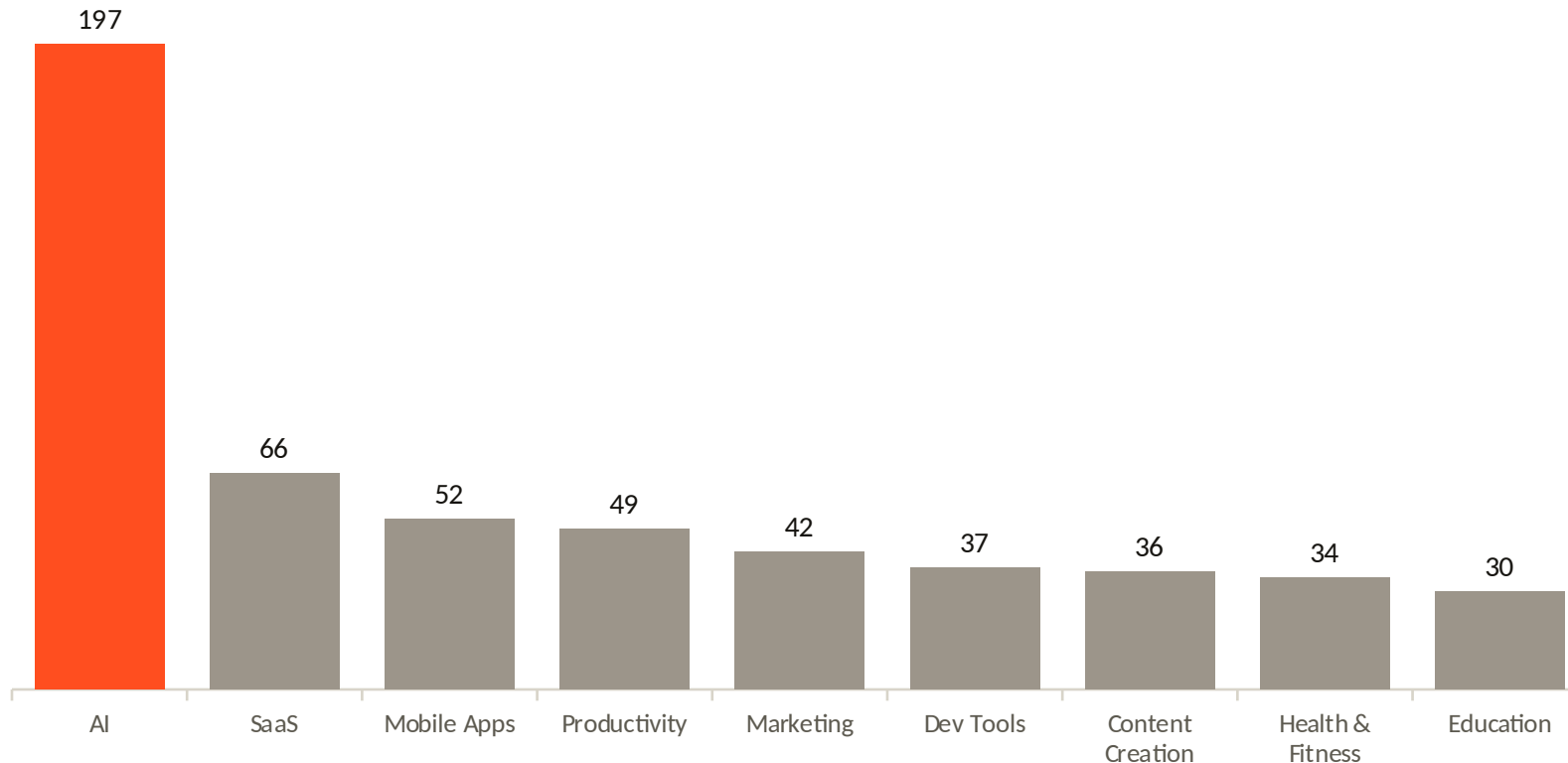
COMBINED MRR (~\$162M ARR RUN-RATE)

262

LISTED FOR ACQUISITION RIGHT NOW (26%)

## SUPPLY

# One category owns the marketplace



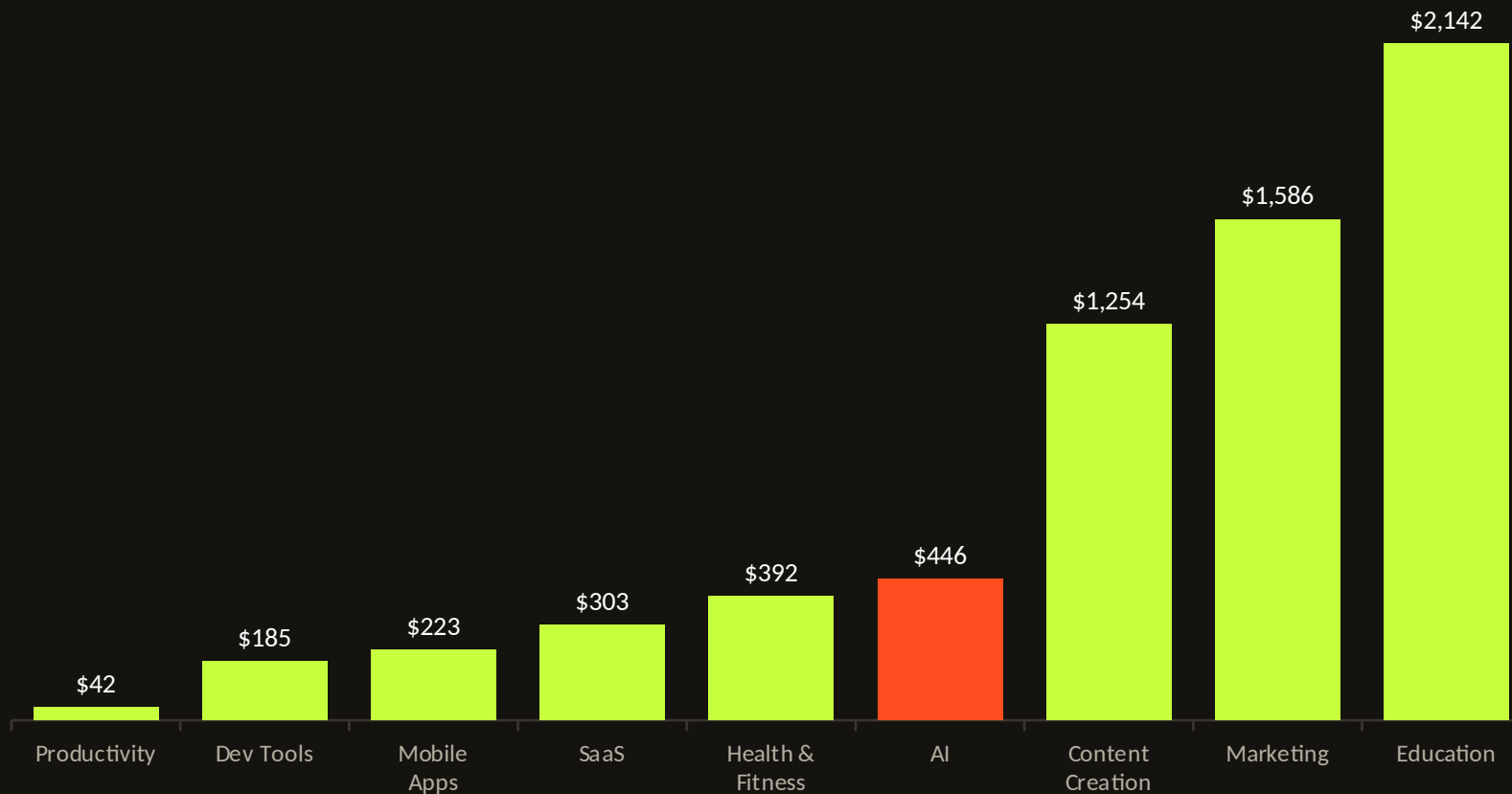
19.7%

of every listing on the marketplace is tagged AI —

*more than the next two categories, SaaS and Mobile Apps, combined.*

## REVENUE

# The hype isn't the earner



4.8x

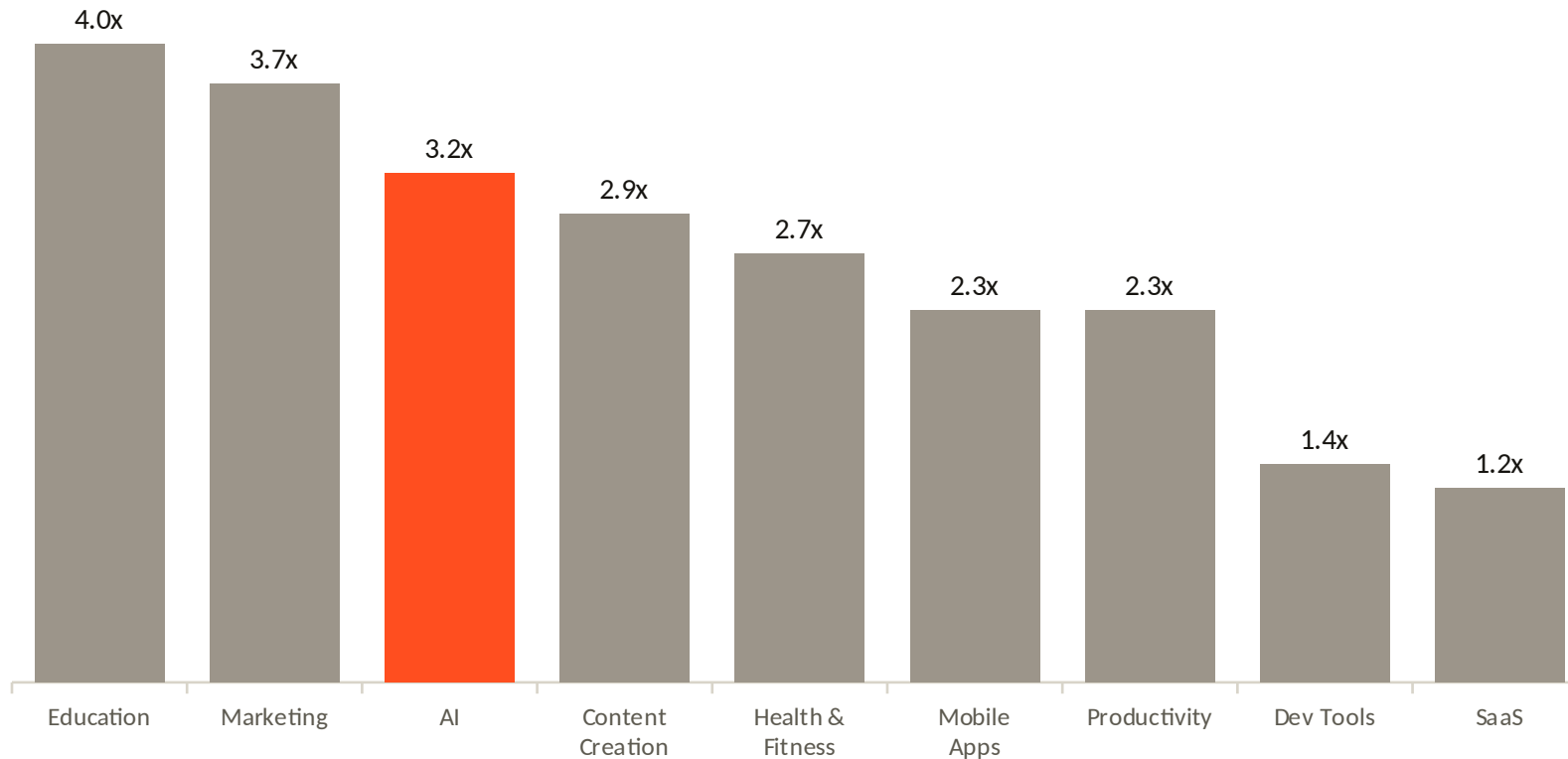
Education's median startup out-earns AI's —

*despite AI listing 6.6x more often on the marketplace.*

## PRICE

# Yet it's priced like a winner

*Median asking-price multiple of trailing revenue, for startups currently listed for sale*



# 3rd

highest resale multiple of 9 major categories —

*for a category that ranks only 6th for revenue per startup.*

## THE THESIS

The AI tag is a  
pricing premium.  
The ledger says  
otherwise.

*Across 1,000 verified listings, buyers are pricing hype — not cash flow.*

## THE clearest tell

# Same buyers. Same marketplace.

*AI vs. SaaS, among startups currently listed for sale (54 and 22 listings respectively)*

### SAAS

\$10,940

median trailing-12mo revenue

1.2x

median resale multiple

### AI

\$7,475

median trailing-12mo revenue — 32% less

3.15x

median resale multiple — 2.6x higher

*A dollar of AI-tagged revenue prices 2.6x higher than a dollar of SaaS revenue — in the same marketplace, the same week.*

# What this means for a buyer

1

## Screen by revenue, not by tag

Set a hard revenue floor before you ever filter by category. A label is not a cash-flow guarantee.

2

## Price against the peer, not the label

SaaS listings show 46% more trailing revenue than AI listings, yet trade at under half the multiple (1.2x vs 3.15x). Check what a non-AI peer would cost first.

3

## Hunt where the label doesn't help

Education, Marketing and Content Creation out-earn AI per startup, often at a comparable or lower multiple. Boring beats buzzy on the ledger.



## READ THE FINE PRINT

- Listings are self-listed on one marketplace (TrustMRR) with connected-payment verification — not audited financials.
- Snapshot frozen 30 Jul 2026; multiples are computed only for the 262 startups currently listed for sale.
- Category multiples rest on 8-54 sale listings each — directional signal, not a precise valuation model.

Buy the ledger.  
Not the label.